New Features in the TextGrid Repository: Facilitating Long-Term Open Access to TEI files

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TextGrid Repository

The TextGrid Repository is a research data repository specialised in TEI files (Neuroth, Rapp, and Söring 2015). Its roots go back almost 20 years and it has been developed and extended through research data infrastructure projects such as DARIAH-DE, CLARIAH-DE and currently under the German NFDI consortium Text+ (Calvo Tello et al. 2023). Documents are not only openly accessible in the repository, it's open and cost-free to all researchers, regardless of institution or country, language or genre of document. The repository is provided by the Göttingen State and University Library and the GWDG. The data is harvested on record level by several resources, such as OpenAire (Weimer 2021), EOSC Resource Hub,[1] or the CLARIN Virtual Language Observatory.

Some of the basic features of the repository are transformation of TEI files into HTML or plain text, bulk download options, assignment of PIDs, recompilation of corpora using the shelf function, on-the-fly connection to other tools such as the Voyant Tools or the CLARIN Switchboard, or access to the data via APIs. This covers a range of use cases: just reading the text, use in classroom, or application of NLP methods. The repository has also been certified with the CoreTrustSeal.

New *Fluffy* Import

One of the challenges since the beginning of the TextGrid repository has been the integration of new projects. This difficulty was partly due to technological challenges, but also to the complexity of the repository's metadata model. In recent years, we have addressed this issue with the clear aim of creating a more user-friendly and less demanding import workflow: the Fluffy Import.

Firstly, projects now have personal support and advice on project data, trying to improve the quality of metadata with minimal effort. Secondly, the import workflow takes place in a Jupyter Notebook environment using several new (tg-model, Notebook Actions) components, APIs, and standard services (tg-crud, tg-publish) of TextGrid (Buddenbohm et al. 2024). This new import assumes that most of the required metadata is already present in the TEI files and that this data can be retrieved via xPaths. The workflow suggests xPaths and the main task of the researcher is to confirm or correct these xPaths. This way, the user is no longer required to fully understand the metadata model. Moreover, the import process allows researchers to curate their metadata when it is not available in the original TEI file, thereby improving its FAIR status (Wilkinson et al. 2016).

New Features

Besides the new import workflow, several other features have been implemented recently. For the ELTeC corpora (see next section) several new metadata fields and facets have been added, including the author's gender.

Projects can now use the Basic Classification (an open resource widely used in the German-speaking libraries) to classify their data into specific disciplines (Calvo Tello et al. 2023; Balakrishnan and Voß 2022; Schulz 1991). In addition, projects can

now use the entities of the GND authority file system to describe, for example, the genre of the publication. Other new features relate to project-specific aspects, such as a configurable landing page and project-specific XSLT transformations.

In addition to the existing API for TextGrid, data can now also be accessed via a Python library (Hynek et al. 2024). This allows researchers to filter and access data in the TextGrid Repository in a programming environment as they would in a browser. In addition, the repository has recently made it possible for researchers to publish TEI data derived from copyrighted documents that cannot be published in their original form (Calvo Tello et al. 2025).[2]

New Corpora

For a long time, the TextGrid Repository was mainly known for the TextGrid Digital Library (Betz 2015), a large collection of German texts.[3] Recently, new German corpora have been added, such as "The Beginnings of German Modern Poetry Corpus".[4] Furthermore, in recent years the team behind the repository has made great efforts to make the repository truly multilingual by adding resources in languages other than German. Some examples of this are the corpus of Spanish novels CoNSSA (Calvo Tello 2021),[5] the collection of corpora in Romance languages textbox (Schöch et al. 2019),[6] the collection of French novels[7] or the The Folger Digital Texts.[8] The publication of 15 of the ELTeC corpora was a major milestone, with hundreds of texts in Romance, Germanic, Slavic and Finno-Ugric languages (Schöch et al. 2021; Burnard, Schöch, and Carolin Odebrecht 2021; Rißler-Pipka et al. 2023). Later, a collection of Caucasian folklore was published, with tales in languages such as Georgian, Russian, Avaric, Tsez and Mingrelian.[9]

We are currently working on the preparation of several new corpora, in German, of a large multilingual corpus of the Bible (Christodouloupoulos and Steedman 2015),[10] and on the integration of the Göttingen Register of Electronic Texts in Indian Languages (GRETIL)[11] with hundreds of documents in Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, Tamil and other Asian languages.

With this poster, we would like to invite more researchers from the DH community to publish their data in TEI in the TextGrid Repository and to benefit from its current and future features.

Notes

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